



SEAMUS HUGHES

240.472.8570 (signal)

seamus@courtwatch.news

www.courtwatch.news

TIP SHEET

PACER -- www.PACER.gov

Great for searching nationally. The database is not updated in real time, so if you have a breaking news case you need to go to the individual court website where it was filed.

Courtlistener -- www.courtlistener.com/recap

- Download RECAP extension on your browser -- <https://free.law/recap>
- Great for doing key word searches on topics.
- You won't break news with Courtlistener but it's a good way to start an investigation or get a sense of the naming conventions of how they file things in your district

ECF

- Search the district you care about + ECF. So if you're looking for documents in the Eastern District of Virginia, google "EDVA ECF"
- Under reports, click on criminal, then criminal reports. In the drop down menu, it matches with the U.S. Code for charges.
- *Example: if you're looking for every arrest involving terrorism criminal cases in that district, pick 18 U.S.C. 2339 in the drop down.*
- Under reports, click on civil and criminal cases, then docket activity. You set the date, then run it for everything that was filed in that specific district during the timeframe

Searches

On Pacer.gov, search national index, then advanced party search.

- You can search by the plaintiff/defendants name but you can also search by the lawyers associated with the case.
- *Example: Lawyers tend to specialize in things, so an Assistant U.S. Attorney that has worked national security cases in the past will likely work them in the future.*

Searches (continued)

On Pacer.gov, search national index, then advanced case search.

- You can search by title of the docket. The * sign is a wildcard search.
- *Example: If you search "us*\$" you'd get all the civil forfeiture cases.*

On courtlistener.com/recap, look for patterns.

- *Example: Care about January 6th cases? Search "cordoned", law enforcement tends to use the same language in similar cases, look for words that wouldn't normally show up in documents.*

Docket Schedule

- Most federal court websites have a public facing docket schedule on their site. Use it to see what's happening in your district today

Courthouse

- You can search for free at any clerk's office. Some documents are only available at the courthouse
- *Example: Lawsuits involving international students suing over the loss of their visa is not available on pacer.gov but is available at the clerk's office.*

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